guidelines and aligning their laws with the new constitutional mandate regarding compensation. States that had enacted land ceiling laws earlier modified them.

For determining the level of ceiling, the guidelines suggested broad principles and left actual determination to the states. They proposed that a ‘family holding’ may be considered from two aspects: as an operational unit, and as an area of land that can yield a certain average income. If the states found it difficult to correlate a family holding to a given level of income adjusted to a supposed level of prices, they could exercise their judgement to decide the area of land that might be declared a family holding. They were also delegated the authority to decide whether the ceiling should apply to individual holdings or to holdings of families; and, especially in the latter case, the basis on which the size of the family should be allowed in the application of the ceiling.

These guidelines paved the way for implementation of agricultural land ceiling in the country. The Punjab Land Reforms Act was enacted in 1972 and The Rajasthan Imposition of Ceiling on Agricultural Holding Act in 1973. Many other states followed. States that had enacted land ceiling laws earlier brought these in line with the new guidelines and constitutional provisions. The Tamil Nadu Land Reforms (Fixation of Ceiling on Land) Act, 1961, was modified in 1970 and ceilings made applicable from 1970. Maharashtra had also adopted land ceilings in 1961, which were extensively modified in the 1970s.

In all, the states declared 2.7 million hectares land as surplus, i.e., the land in excess of land ceiling. Of this declared surplus, 2.3 million (87 per cent) hectares were possessed and 1.9 million hectares distributed to 5.5 million households (37 per cent to scheduled castes [SCs] and 16 per cent to scheduled tribes [STs]).

The land ceiling issue was largely forgotten after the 1980s. A Committee on Land Reforms appointed by the United Progressive Alliance